

Anti-racist Rhetorical Praxis in the 1960s-70s *Tech News/The Paper* at the City College of New York

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ABSTRACT: This historical case study of the extraordinary student journalism at the City College of New York from 1966 to 1970 directly answers Keith Gilyard's 2016 call to study these radical Black¹ and Puerto Rican student voices. We hope this example can be useful to educators, students, and communities who seek not only to oppose monolingual writing, testing and teaching systems, but to coalesce anti-racist sites of learning, literacy, and action.

KEYWORDS: anti-racism; City College of New York (CCNY); decolonization; desegregation; Francee Covington; Louis Reyes Rivera; Mina Shaughnessy; Paul Simms; praxis; rhetoric; student journalism; The Paper / Tech News

It is only when the oppressed find the oppressor out and become involved in the organized struggle for their liberation that they begin to believe in themselves. This discovery cannot be purely intellectual but must involve action; nor can it be limited to mere activism, but must include serious reflection: only then will it be a praxis. —Paulo Freire, 1967

While practice without theory bangs its head against a brick wall, theory without practice lulls itself to sleep. —Assata Shakur, *The Paper*, 20 Feb. 1975

We have united in a struggle to drastically change certain aspects of this college—changes we feel are in the interests of Black and Puerto Rican students. —Paul B. Simms, *Tech News*, 19 Feb. 1967

Anti-Racist Student Journalism as a Historical Case Study

From February of 1966 to November of 1970, a small group of student journalists and editors at City College of New York (CCNY) in Harlem—including Francee Covington, Louis Reyes Rivera, and Paul Simms—trans-

formed a conservative student newspaper, *Tech News*, into a powerful, transgressive voice for change. In the fall of 1970, they renamed it *The Paper*; CCNY students still publish *The Paper* today.² Covington and other SEEK students (“Search for Education, Elevation, and Knowledge,” an admissions desegregation and supportive teaching program) also published at least one issue of their own version of “*The Paper*,” just three weeks after the April 1968 assassination of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. (*The Paper*; Simms and Simms; Covington, “Oral History” 438–40).

In line with the desegregating, decolonial, community-control demands that Black and Puerto Rican student activists were lodging at the City University of New York (CUNY) in this moment, these publications were intentionally multivocal and multilingual as a creative and political *praxis*. Their actions and writing refused the university’s white-supremacist, western, English monolingual logics that were reified through writing pedagogies and school policies at the time (as discussed further in this issue’s introduction). Here, we celebrate remarkable Black and Puerto Rican student journalism at City College—as an articulation of campus activism—that culminated with the 1969 Harlem University takeover, official birth of *The Paper*, and transition into the City University’s Open Admissions era.

In his 2016 essay “The Rhetoric of Translingualism,” Keith Gilyard concluded that “[o]ne of the strongest moves that” critical language scholars “can make is to document students’ efforts” via “deeper study of powerfu[l]” student activist writing: “We need the stories of struggle. . . and those should include tales of triumph” (288, 284). In this piece, we offer a historical case study of the metamorphosis of *Tech News* into *The Paper* from 1966 to 1970

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as one illustration of praxis by author-activists who are embedded in racial justice and anti-colonial movement work on campus and beyond.

This article is part of a larger archival and interview project to preserve the voices of City College writing teachers and students who both desegregated City College and fought to transform it. In particular, this article is in conversation with our 2021 conversation with Paul Simms (Simms and Simms). Sean has previously used the City College SEEK program as a historical case study in a similar way to examine ecological writing assessment models (Molloy, *Convenient Myopia*, “Human Beings”). Anna has studied and written about CUNY student activist writing, including newspapers and other public-facing literacies in the context of emergent forms of racial capitalism and movement building in the 1990s (Zeemont). Coco wrote a book on the rise of Black, Puerto Rican, and Women’s Studies and movements at City College and in New York City, including the role of student writing and organizing (Reed, *Liberation School*). Coco was also a journalist and editor on the staff of *The Paper* for two years while a CCNY undergraduate from 2006 to 2010.

Our connections to these literacies underscore that the stories we tell here are not abstractions but based in the intellectual, rhetorical and political labor and experiences of real people. Materially grounded in a specific situation of radical Black and Puerto Rican student literacy/action, our essay aims to be useful to educators, students, and communities seeking to not only oppose monolingual writing testing and teaching systems, but to re-envision sites of learning and literacy to transform society altogether by dismantling the linguistic hierarchies it upholds and uses to sanction material dispossession in contexts such as the policing of migrants and global imperialism/militarism (Rose; Rosa and Flores).

To illustrate what anti-racist rhetorical praxis can look like on the ground, we offer this historical case study of student writing at CCNY. We believe that expressly anti-racist rhetorics always oppose monolingualism in practice and that the student authors of *Tech News/The Paper* demonstrated that opposition in myriad ways. Grounded in political struggle rather than in top-down, institutionally sanctioned literacy pedagogies, these students understood writing as more than a performance of hegemonic whitestream monolingualism. They understood their writing as rhetorically grounded and specifically located in real situations with real audiences and consequences. In the late 1960s, at a historical moment of growing pedagogical shallowness, cruelty, and conservatism on one side of the public university, and the blossoming of an uncharted radical learning process on the other

side, these literacy experimentations and student writing at *Tech News/The Paper* emerged as a pivotal site of sophisticated linguistic and political insurgence at CCNY.

Failures and Possibilities of Recognizing Radical Student Writing

Anti-colonial and anti-racist infusions of a range of expressions in the classroom were born of the last apex of social movements in the 1960s and 70s. This included efforts to validate immensely varied African, Asian, Caribbean, European, Latin American, Middle Eastern, and Pacific diasporic and transnational forms of student speech and writing (Conference on College Composition and Communication; Perl; Smitherman, “Raciolinguistics”). These experimental pedagogies were catalyzed by overlapping immigration waves to US urban centers, campaigns to desegregate and decolonize public universities, and efforts to create bilingual learning programs. For decades now, these anti-racist interventions—grounded in activism beyond the classroom—have pushed back against monolingual, formalist, and race-evasive writing pedagogies and teaching systems that historically characterized US composition instruction, all often enforced by exclusionary mass writing test systems. Though such interventions took place in pedagogical settings across the globe, they crystallized in unique and powerful ways in the context of CUNY’s transformative movement to desegregate admissions, decolonize curricula, and welcome inside broader social struggles (Okechukwu; Reed).

Beginning in 1965, SEEK Program writing instructors at City College—such as Barbara Christian, Toni Cade Bambara, David Henderson, June Jordan, Audre Lorde, and Adrienne Rich—developed remarkable critical pedagogies with their students, soon catalyzing their college campus to undergo an existential reinvention. Bambara invited her students to determine the subjects and methods of their studies (Bambara). Henderson brought in non-Western texts such as *One Thousand and One Nights*, and urged students to write about their family histories (Reed). Jordan ferried in oratory and journalism honed from collaborations with Malcolm X, Louis Lomax, and Buckminster Fuller in Harlem (Jordan). Lorde marveled at her own learning process about grammar and poetics alongside her students (Lorde). Rich foregrounded Black liberation texts and writing assignments that explored social transformation (Rich). That same year, poet Denise Levertov and dramatists Jack Gelber and Paddy Chavessky initiated a CCNY writer-in-residence program (Volpe, “[1966] Report” 4). A steady stream of

poets, dramatists, and creative writers brought new approaches and complex process pedagogies. In 1967, lecturer Mark Mirsky, having taught in John Hawkes' Stanford "Voice Project" earlier that year, brought that voice writing course model to CCNY, where Mirsky led several "practicing young novelists [to] see what they can do to breathe new life into the teaching of freshman writing" (Volpe, "[1967] Report" 4). Meanwhile, a group of CCNY student journalists were writing and publishing increasingly powerful and sophisticated articles and editorials (more on this below).

Ironically, at the same time that this liberatory arc of writing pedagogy in the classroom and student journalism emerged, monolingual sentence-level formalism recruited a great champion at CCNY. In April of 1967, Mina Shaughnessy was hired as a SEEK writing course lecturer by the CCNY English Department. Shaughnessy's conservative writing pedagogy, which she would soon label "Basic Writing", was quickly embraced by a conservative CCNY English Department, even as many of Shaughnessy's SEEK colleagues engaged in a proliferation of inventive (and non-punitive) teaching and writing pedagogies. In 1969 and 1970, CCNY created and expanded a new deeply error-centric and formalist "Basic Writing" course and testing program. By 1971, Basic Writing courses and high stakes writing tests dominated all writing instruction at CCNY. By 1972, Shaughnessy had complete control over first-year composition courses, a growing list of new timed-writing tests, and a basic skills-focused writing center (Molloy, *Convenient Myopia* 221–308). Of course, basic skills pedagogies were not new. They dated back at least a century. But by the early 1960s, it was clear that they were superficial, biased, and ineffective. By reframing basic skills as "Basic Writing" and by imagining a huge group of "Basic Writers" who would benefit from it, Shaughnessy breathed new life into this old, failed approach—rebranding it as new, sophisticated, and compassionate.

White public college systems from Georgia to Wisconsin, to California to New Jersey, embraced similar Basic Writing course/testing systems during the 1970s (Molloy and Bennett 27). These Basic Writing course/testing systems immediately targeted Brown, Black, multilingual, neurodiverse and working-class students for cruel and abusive treatment. Sometimes administrators were candid about their racist intentions (Molloy and Bennett; Molloy, Fonville, and Salam). Shaughnessy herself admitted privately that the new CUNY basic skills "penalized testing" system would decimate students of color in what would be understood to be a "desperate and educationally irresponsible move." Yet, she pushed it forward (Shaughnessy, note to Murphy 3; Molloy, *Convenient Myopia* 376–86).

In Shaughnessy's shadow, the field of composition-rhetoric has often failed to capture the race-radical nature of multi-discursive modes of student communication born out of social movements of this late 1960s period (Albracht; Kynard, *Vernacular*). Instead, traditionalist basic skills frameworks have abounded—such as those endorsing writing exams, prompted five-paragraph essays, enforced code switching, and formalist and error-centric assessment practices—all of which are inevitably anti-Black and anti-migrant in their confinement to what April Baker-Bell calls “White Mainstream English.” Such traditionalist pedagogical regimes uphold monolingualism in the sense that Bruce Horner and Sara Alvarez define it—as a persistent dominant ideology which:

posits languages as stable, internally uniform, and discrete from one another. Each language is identified with a particular nationality and/or race/ethnicity. . . and language users are expected to have a single such language as their birthright as its “native speakers.” Their ostensible command of that language (as monolith), achieved naturally through advance to adulthood, is posited as the target for others to aim for, however unlikely these others may be to reach that target. (6)

In a US context, the interconnectedness between monolingual supremacy and “nativism”/birthright makes plain that these kinds of language ideologies are settler-colonial and anti-Black in nature, as Indigenous and Black language ways have been deemed antithetical to those of a white, US citizen ideal (Rosa and Flores). These ideologies systematically obscure the reality that literacy, “language and language standards are situational, political, arbitrary, and palimpsestic” (Gilyard 284; see also Smitherman, “Raciolinguistics”; Pritchard). Writing and language beyond the bounds of what Eric Darnell Pritchard calls “literacy normativity” push against and reimagine standard definitions of what literacy can do.

The kinds of radical, linguistically expansive, literacy pedagogies embodied by teachers and students engaged in movement work still have not been fully centered in composition-rhetoric. A key reason may be that teacher-scholars are embedded in a public imaginary that understands students at institutions like CUNY—the majority of whom are Black, Brown, and/or multilingual—as incapable of real intellectual work or sophisticated writing (Kynard, *Vernacular*; Zeemont). Research in raciolinguistics—or, per Geneva Smitherman, the study of “language and/as race” (“Raciolinguistics”)—tells

us that hegemonic language ideologies “conflate certain racialized bodies with linguistic deficiency unrelated to any objective linguistic practices,” with the perspective of a “white listening subject” as default (Flores and Rosa 150). In studies around CUNY pedagogy in composition-rhetoric around and after Open Admissions, there is indeed a history of student writers being conceived of solely or primarily through what Eve Tuck calls “damage-centered” paradigms, often premised on anti-Blackness, with the vantage point of white professors as the implicit default (Kynard, *Vernacular*; Zeemont; Lamos). This can even be the case with scholars who have espoused commitments to linguistic equity (whether labeled as “translingual” or “anti-racist”) contradict their praxis and lead them to deem conservative, traditionalist pedagogies as most appropriate for a Black and Brown student population (Kynard, *Vernacular*; Baker-Bell et al.).

Black and Brown students and scholars have always been on the frontlines of clarifying this myopia. In a piece focusing on more recent Black students at CUNY as they multimodally compose in conversation with the Movement for Black Lives, Kynard cites the writing of “conscious and critical Black students” as offering a uniquely brilliant capacity to trace “the intimate, lived experiences of Black people’s struggles over the rhetorical projects of schooling under colonization” (“Black Digital-Cultural”). We are inspired by her idea that critical and activist-oriented rhetorical work marks a sophisticated part of “the daily work they do to actually revise the . . . codes of our universities and social systems” (“Black Digital-Cultural”)—from calling out and demanding the upheaval of anti-Black writing curriculum and classroom practices (Suh 116–17), to creating self-fashioned, race-radical spaces of writing and learning (Kynard, *Vernacular*; Reed; Zeemont).

Both Keith Gilyard and Carmen Kynard call for scholars to attend to the writing contexts of the 1960s and 1970s at the City College of New York in predominantly Black and Puerto Rican Harlem as one vital space to understand literacy as praxis. Indeed, *Tech News/The Paper*’s activist student writers offered a sophisticated and profound epistemology of writing that, foremost, was intimately intertwined with movement-building, centered the lived realities of Black and Puerto Rican communities, and subverted and defied white linguistic and rhetorical norms. These student writers operated in a linguistic space beyond the classroom that we understand as in, “but not of,” the university (to borrow the language of Stefano Harney and Fred Moten). This kind of insurgent movement literacy work came to fruition in spite of the success and growth of education barriers and tiering mechanisms like writing tests and zero-credit course systems, as well as, in a

larger sense, “pernicious language instruction—in some cases the linguistics of white supremacy” (Gilyard 286).

Anti-racist Rhetorical Praxis Emerges in *Tech News*

The first *Tech News* issue of the Fall 1965 semester showed it to be a relatively unremarkable newspaper by and for CCNY engineering, science, and architecture students focused mostly on job prospects and starting salaries for graduating engineers. Large ads recruited students to join the US Air Force and IBM, with no mention of how the military-industrial complex would employ their talents in Viet Nam. The *Tech News* staffers were not, however, completely imperceptive to the world beyond their campus. One article noted the pending resignation of Kenneth Clark as the head of a campus “Social Dynamics Research Laboratory” and cited Clark’s important civil rights work (*Tech News*, “Prof. Clark” 1). Elsewhere, an editorial argued:

Our primary responsibility as an urban school is to become a working unit of the community—to work with the existing social agencies, to aid the elementary and secondary school in whatever way we can and to institute programs of self-help and rehabilitation.

Efforts to meet that responsibility, said the editors, would “remain insufficient until the entire student body awakens to the needs of the community and reacts through student participation” (*Tech News*, “Responsibility” 2).

During this time, by one estimate, less than 2% of the entire CUNY student body was Black (Curri van). James L. Hicks, the editor of Harlem’s Black-owned newspaper *The New York Amsterdam News*, repeatedly attacked CUNY’s racial exclusion and anti-Blackness. He argued that its admissions requirements were fundamentally biased because many Black students received “inferior educational training” in the City’s public schools (“Gets Higher” 9). Hicks opined that CUNY would refuse to admit “God himself unless he presents an affidavit showing he is white and able to meet the IQ tests laid down by the Board. . .” and repeatedly called CCNY as “lily-white” as “Ole Miss University” (“Higher Board” 11; “Rescue” 11; “Gets Higher” 9). Only about a year after a July 1964 mass neighborhood rebellion against police who shot and killed 15-year-old James Powell,³ CCNY remained largely indifferent to the systemic racism (specifically anti-Blackness), police brutality, poverty, and injustice afflicting its neighboring communities and many others throughout the country.

In the spring of 1966, Paul B. Simms was a first-year, pre-med Black student at City College with an interest in genetics. One of the few Black students admitted under CCNY's exclusionary system, Simms was soon troubled that his overwhelmingly white college was completely disconnected from the concerns of the Black and Puerto Rican communities of Harlem, West Harlem, Manhattanville, and Hamilton Heights which surrounded it. He soon found two "sites" of activism to "maneuver through" this white system. One site of activism was the Black Science Students Organization ("BSSO") that Simms co-founded. The other was *Tech News* (Simms and Simms).

Immediately upon joining the *Tech News* staff, Simms began to expand the scope, tenor, and purpose of *the paper* by reporting about Harlem. In February 1966, Simms' first article spotlighted Harlem communities' backlash to a proposed City College expansion project—including a sports stadium that would be built in nearby St. Nicholas Park. Simms also directly challenged CCNY's failure to admit more Black and Puerto Rican students. He interviewed Amsterdam News' Hicks, who opposed the project—and who Simms pointedly quoted as labeling City College a "white Rhodesia." Simms also spoke with CCNY President Buell Gallagher (Simms, "Under Fire" 1). Gallagher cited a new pilot program (later named SEEK) through which the College had recently admitted and supported 114 mostly Black and Puerto Rican students (2).

Even prior to writing in a style that overtly embodied formal features of Black language (which later came to characterize his journalism), Simms engaged in rhetorically effective, anti-racist activism both by challenging his college's encroachment on its neighbors and by directly pressing the issue of racial exclusion with several sources, including the CCNY President—and then centering these questions for *Tech News* readers. These moves were mostly substantive, not formal: Simms followed the major surface conventions of a news report in a white student newspaper for a largely white audience. But Simms subverted the conventional purpose of a "neutral" news report as a junior reporter within the existing power structure. He chose a story, found sources, and asked questions, all of which reframed the issues of racial segregation and CUNY land gentrification in a way that directly challenged the white college system and its obligations to both surrounding communities and to the city's high school students. Simms began the piece by outlining the major, politicized concerns of community members: "they should not let an all white school take over a section of a public park" mostly used by its Black neighbors, who also "have no assurance that they will benefit" from its construction—saving a description of what the con-

struction would consist of until the last paragraphs continued on a later page (“Under Fire” 1–2). Simms’ chosen title—“St. Nicholas Park Program Under Fire From Community”—also centered the concerns of the people of Harlem. By comparison, a New York Times article on the same topic was entitled “A Field Is Sought by City College; It Plans to Use St. Nicholas Park for Varsity Teams.” By using passive voice to make “a field” the article’s subject, the *Times* downplayed CCNY administrators’ active responsibility for the proposal’s potential consequences; indeed, the article *only* discusses the various benefits that the expansion would have on the school and its sole mention of the local community is that the park—“[h]eavily dotted with jagged boulders”—“is virtually unused by the neighborhood residents” (“A Field”).⁴ Simms’ very choice to deem this issue as newsworthy, coupled with what may seem like inconsequential morphosyntactic choices, were thus active, critical, and unique rhetorical decisions of embodied writing. Scholar Alexis Pauline Gumbs calls this practice “community accountability,” one rooted in what scholar Eric Darnell Pritchard traces as within a longer legacy of Black activist literacies.

In 1967, Simms conducted an interview series with prominent Black leaders including *The Liberator’s* Dan Watts, Congress on Racial Equality’s Floyd McKissick, Nation of Islam’s Louis Farrakhan, United Afro-American Association’s William Wright, comedian activist Dick Gregory, and Thelma Johnson, the New York City Assistant Deputy Commissioner for Human Resources (Simms, “Dan Watts,” “McKissick Accuses,” “Minister [Farrakhan],” “U.A.A.A.,” “Black Comic,” “Bootblacks”). Across those interviews, Simms platformed a range of strategic and discursive approaches to Black community organizing on issues of nonviolence, self-defense, community control, and decentralization of education. The series was radical enough that the editors felt a need to add a disclaimer that the positions taken by Simms and his subjects did not “necessarily reflect the views of the Managing Board of *TECH NEWS*.” In this series, Simms used a seemingly “conventional” interview format to embed radical shifts in subject, viewpoint, and argument. Across his interviews, Thelma Johnson called for the decentralization of New York City’s deeply segregated and unequal school system (“Bootblacks”). Dan Watts flatly disagreed that access to education was the key to fighting racism: “America has moved too far ahead for education to achieve for the black man his place in this white society. Power must be applied. Violence must be demonstrated” (Watts, quoted in Simms, “Black Rights” 2). CORE leader McKissick decried an “educational system that is teaching black minds to be white puppets.” Like Watts, McKissick refused to rule out violent responses

to systemic racism. “I have been the victim of violence. We at CORE are not going to lie down and get beaten to death. We do not, however, advocate the use of aggressive violence; only as a protective measure” (McKissick, quoted in Simms, “Miseducation” 3). Through his position as a Black journalist, Simms welcomed interviewees to force his collegiate audience to confront polemics about American racism.

Within a campus newspaper that had featured primarily white authors, and privileged monolingual “White Mainstream English” and deracialized perspectives, Simms foregrounded a chorus of new voices to identify the concerns of Harlem residents and its political advocates. He also chronicled how Black and Puerto Rican students deliberately collaborated with each other on their own terms (Baker-Bell). For example, Simms obtained exclusive coverage of a campus meeting between the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC) chairperson H. Rapp Brown and Black and Puerto Rican CCNY students—a meeting which white students were prohibited from attending—during which Brown asserted, “Education is not the solution; you must begin to practice the things you learn here” (“Rapp Lectures”).

Simms’ journalism practiced the multivocality of Black radicalism, bringing in wisdom and actions from the community. He chose this approach rather than centering the definitive ideas of a singular writer-subject bound to “campus” concerns of a “typical” student newspaper, as if students and pedagogues were discrete from the era’s political movements rather than in conversation with them. In his writing, Simms highlighted a range of expressive and organizing strategies for Black and Puerto Rican liberation *both within and across* their various marginalized rhetorical groups. Working collectively with other students and faculty to pressure the college (and all-white colleges) into real and fundamental reforms, Simms soon pivoted his writing to urge *Tech News* readers to learn from Black educational experimentations in Harlem to envision how the college’s curricular infrastructure could be reconfigured to include the study and involvement of Black lives.⁵

In 1968, when Simms began to serve as the *Tech News* editor-in-chief, the entire focus and voice of the newspaper shifted. Simms documented the 1968 UFT teachers’ strike and the simultaneous creation of “freedom schools” across Harlem (“Struck Schools”). Simms then printed a series of “From a Black Chair” Op-Eds in which he moved from journalism to direct advocacy and switched to a more openly opinionated, reflective voice. For example, in December of 1968, he laid out blueprints for what an autonomous “Black University” could look like within City College, as *the campus* administration failed to propose any clear plan to desegregate its studies.

Simms proposed fundamental changes:

The University would have courses in African History, Afro-American History, Black Culture (both African and Afro-American), Black Contemporary Thought, Asian History, Garveyism, The Lives and Works of Malcolm X, DuBois, Douglass, Fanon and Che, Coalitions with the Left, Revolutionary Actions, American Hypocrisy, American Atrocities, Socialism and its Relevance to Black Nationalism, and other similar courses. Some of these courses could be taught by students, others could be taught by outside teachers. A Black student referendum could determine which courses should be given and which were omitted. It would be expected that every Black student on campus, whether enrolled in the university or not, would contribute to the maintenance of this institution. ("Black Studies")

In the racist milieu of the 1968 New York City public school teachers' strike to oppose Black and Puerto Rican community governance, and CCNY's refusal to recognize the legitimacy of Black Studies, Simms showed how an anti-racist rhetorical praxis can go beyond classroom writing to alter the operations and curricular infrastructure of schooling within broader social movements.

In a page-long opinion piece, "From a Black Chair: Politics, American Style," published on November 13, 1968—eight days after the 1968 Presidential election—Simms channeled his rage over the election of Richard Nixon and the almost ten million votes cast for the apartheid leader George Wallace. Grounding his writing in the rhetorical tradition of Black language and its features like narrative sequencing and signifying (Smitherman, *Talkin*; Richardson; Rickford and Rickford), Simms meshed together styles, voices, and even fictional dialogue. He quoted the Declaration of Independence. He raged at the election of Nixon and white working-class support for Wallace. In the wake of the election, Simms attacked George Foreman for waving a United States flag in a boxing ring. "It really hurts to see a brother bought off like that." Simms even included a fictional dialogue about the election: "'Hey man, did you see that jive honkey gonna stand on the corner of 125th Street and tell me I should go to church, God damn! I'm tired of trying to save my soul; I want to get with my body'" (3). Here, Simms used a variety of registers in combination to express the pain he felt over the undeniable demonstration of American racism. (In addition to Nixon's election, Wallace carried five states and 13% of the national vote.) Rhetorically, Simms' writing

underwent a symbiotic metamorphosis: as these textual experimentations changed the pages of *Tech News*, the historical conditions of his time were also shaping him, as inflected through his writing. Gradually, other Black and Puerto Rican students joined Simms at *Tech News*.

Praxis Intervenes in the 1968 SEEK Version of *The Paper*

As *Tech News* underwent dramatic changes, another Black student literacy project arose that demonstrates the power of student-activated literacies to effect rhetorical and institutional changes in public higher education during this time of social upheavals. This was initiated by Francee Covington, who had arrived at City College in 1966. She recalled, “I had a lot of experience organizing way before entering City College”—after all, “this was still Jim Crow New York” (Molloy, *Convenient Myopia* 29, 82). Covington had been arrested at the age of fourteen when protesting the SUNY Downstate Medical Center’s refusal to hire Black and Puerto Rican construction workers, and in 1964 she had marched on Washington and attended CORE actions to desegregate public schools (Reed, *New York Liberation School* 127). In 1968, Covington started a SEEK student newspaper called *The Paper*, published three weeks after Martin Luther King, Jr.’s assassination. Toni Cade Bambara was listed as the faculty advisor, and Paul Simms received special mention for helping with its production. Although only one issue of this iteration of *The Paper* has survived, its style and scope presaged the transition from *Tech News* to *The Paper* two years later.

Multiple movement reports in SEEK’s *The Paper* traced how Black and Puerto Rican students were mobilizing across CUNY and New York City to “act against racism, war, [and] the draft” (Moreno 3). The issue also reported threats to the \$3.5 million annual funding for the SEEK program itself, which was both the main vehicle for desegregation of CUNY’s four-year colleges and the largest white college desegregation program in the country (Covington, “Expansion” 1). Another article reported a student meeting with Mayor Lindsay demanding community control of the New York Police Department (NYPD) and an expansion of SEEK (“Lindsay Ignores” 1). A special essay by Bambara lauded Covington and other SEEK students’ intellectual and political development as far surpassing the orthodox limits of CCNY’s classrooms: “a sufficient number have become skilled and therefore liberated and are ready to tell me to get out of the way for they have things to do on their own” (“Something” 4).

Here again we see anti-racist rhetorical praxis expressed as student

journalist activism. Some of these SEEK students were protest leaders—including Covington, who was the sole woman member of the “Committee of Ten” of Black and Puerto Rican student organizers who would soon lead a springtime revolt. With active assistance from Bambara and other SEEK educators, these students rallied communities at CCNY and across New York City to effect change by publishing stories, voices, and arguments that reshaped the cultures of *the campuses* and neighborhoods. Their merging of writing and action soon contributed to a tipping point that would transform City College and CUNY.

Movement Literacies and the 1969 Protests

In the spring of 1969, Black and Puerto Rican students, including many in the SEEK Program, coordinated a series of protests at City College, as well as composed Five Demands to change the admissions, curriculum, campus governance, teacher training, and the college’s relationship to Harlem. Under Simms’ helm, *Tech News* actively documented this escalation process. On April 22, 1969, this culminated in a seventeen days-long campus occupation of the South Campus, during which Black and Puerto Rican students renamed the college “Harlem University.” The April 23 *Tech News* issue featured on-the-ground reports by multiple students and a list of critical questions by strike-supportive SEEK faculty to the college president (Simms, “Strike Still On”; Braun et al.; Watson; SEEK English Instructors).

Covington was one of the central organizers of *the campus* takeover, and Simms closely documented it behind the barricades (Jezebel Productions; Molloy; Reed). Covington later recalled:

I was there the whole two weeks (spent two nights away). I would go home, take a shower, fresh clothes and snacks, and then go back to campus. Couldn’t get any sleep. Some people would be snoring. I have to be ready for what’s coming. We were exhausted. It was two of the longest weeks God created. . . hiding from your mom. . . ‘I’m working on a paper!’ Press coverage was almost immediate—they were surprised it lasted two weeks. We were on the Daily News front page, television cameras each day. (Reed, *New York Liberation School* 132)

Mayoral candidates were forced to weigh in on the takeover. Paul Simms reported that “during the occupation, several thousand dollars was collected from Harlem residents and other Black and Puerto Rican people and now has

been placed in a bank for use in the School of Third World Studies” (Simms, “What Was Behind”). In a larger temporal context of struggles for Ethnic Studies, Black Studies and Third World liberation at institutions like UC Berkeley and San Francisco State University (Okihiru; Ferguson), City College and the Harlem community became a bellwether for community control, Third World Studies, and the desegregation and decolonization of CUNY.

Simms, Covington, Rivera, and *Tech News* Reach Beyond City College

A year after *the campus* occupation, CUNY adopted an Open Admissions policy that allowed all graduating New York City high schools students to enroll somewhere in the university, and began to implement new Black, Puerto Rican and Latinx, and Asian Studies programs. The pages of *Tech News* astutely narrated the struggles leading from the Harlem University takeover to Open Admissions. By September of 1969, Simms had brought on incoming Afro-Puerto Rican SEEK student and poet-journalist Louis Reyes Rivera to *Tech News*, and they began to recruit a dozen Black and Puerto Rican students, including Covington, to help transform the newspaper. In his first semester at City College, Rivera penned several articles, including on the college’s sudden firing of beloved Black professor Wilfred Cartey from his position in the Urban and Ethnic Studies Department, and a campus visit by a federal agent to seize files of student organizers (Simms and Rivera; Rivera, “Student-Member,” “Student Files”). Simms also reported on a February 1970 student-led “Black Revolutions” class, in which “the entire class felt the need to take over the course and all participated in the development of the curriculum” (Simms, “Black Revolution”). That same month, Rivera reported CUNY announced plans to introduce Open Admissions in the fall of 1970—offering admission to all graduating New York City high school students, but with limited financial and academic support. As many working-class students of color would be funneled into overwhelmed two-year CUNY colleges, Rivera quoted faculty and students who worried that this policy’s unsustainable roll-out would exacerbate the existing race and class stratification within CUNY that the Harlem University’s Five Demands had sought to improve (“Conrad Attacks”). In another May 1970 *Tech News* issue, Francee Covington wrote about a rally in opposition to proposed fee increases and CUNY’s underfunded implementation of Open Admissions, and she was listed in a notice for Black and Puerto Rican students to recommend curriculum for the newly formed Urban and Ethnic Studies Depart-

ment (“Rally vs. Fee”; “Attention”).

Covington, Rivera, and Simms together transcended the error-centric, formalist Basic Writing pedagogy which was then gradually coming to dominate all writing instruction at City with its error-centric formalism and shallow timed tests (Molloy and Bennett). In 2015, Covington recalled: “We were basically on our own, in terms of production of the [*Tech News/The Paper*]; we were on our own. We didn’t have a faculty advisor, we didn’t have somebody who was saying ‘You can’t say this, ‘You gotta do it this way.’ So we invented what we thought would work and it worked well” (Covington, “Oral History”). These student journalists used sophisticated rhetorical and critical methods to grapple with questions of admissions, curriculum, governance, state repression, and the political economy of the shifting university. *Tech News* writer Arlette Ford later recalled that quite “a few of the people at “our” *Tech News* were involved in off-campus local, national, and international political activities, and they, under the leadership of Paul Simms and the subsequent editors-in-chief, collectively brought a powerhouse of organizing know-how, political connections, and writing skills to the *Tech News* enterprise” (A. Ford 527).

Paul Simms and Francee Covington both left City College in May 1970. Their departing salutations in *Tech News* read with the wisdom and grit of seasoned journalists, as their writing reached audiences far beyond the campus walls. The previous summer, Simms’ report on the Black and Puerto Rican students’ campus takeover had been published in the *Harvard Crimson*, radiating strike lessons from Harlem to Ivy League student readers (and their wary administrators). Covington also published an essay, “Are the Revolutionary Techniques Employed in The Battle of Algiers Applicable to Harlem?” in her SEEK teacher Bambara’s landmark 1970 anthology, *The Black Woman*. Assessing the paradigmatic influence of the Algerian revolution on the US Left, Covington dissected how the revolution’s success did not correspond with conditional possibilities for Black radical epicenters like “Harlem, Watts, Howard University,” and elsewhere in the United States. In these two examples, we see how anti-racist rhetorical praxis at City College expanded outward to broader audiences.

In 1970, *Tech News* continued to document CUNY affairs in a wider milieu of social change amidst state violence. Soon, the paper began to eschew individual bylines for a collectivist analysis by the editorial team, which signaled their recomposition as a multi-author force and also likely protected them from repression. Features highlighted *Tech News*’ increasing experimentation with photomontage and other collage techniques that aligned with

their collaborative writing ethos. In a visually arresting double-page feature spread on May 15, 1970, *the paper* mourned the murders of Black students at Texas Southern, Orangeburg, Augusta, Memphis, and Jackson State, and contrasted the public outcry for the four Euro-descended students murdered at Kent State with the more muted response to the cases of the Black students. At the center of the feature sits an illustration of bullet-riddled Black bodies, while a “KENT”-helmeted National Guardsman grins and shakes the hand of a Southern sheriff. In the background, a silhouette emblazoned with the words “JACKSON STATE” recedes into the darkness of social forgetting. The accompanying text charged CUNY officials with complicit silence:

American racism—you can find it in every single facet of life in these United States. From New York to San Francisco, Birmingham to Maine, white people generally act in patterns that are predicated upon keeping Black people down. Only recently, we have seen how the City College administration and the City University have responded to the deaths of the seven brothers, one by prison guards, and six by the Augusta police. There hasn’t been one word out of Copeland or Bowker about the deaths of these Black people. (*Tech News*, “Jackson State”)

The *Tech News* editors increasingly discarded the fiction of journalistic objectivity in favor of an openly partisan approach. They took calls to direct action out of the editorial pages and splayed them across the publication at large. In step with this aim, the “Jackson State” article concludes with a section entitled “What Do We Do Now,” in which the editors proclaim, “Simply the number of cases of brutality and murder committed on the Black peoples of America by this government should force all Black students and Black people to become actively engaged in the struggle for freedom as an oppressed people” (*Tech News*, “Jackson State”).

***Tech News* Transforms into *The Paper* as CUNY Retrenchment Appears**

In the Fall 1970 semester, the *Tech News* team under Rivera’s editorial helm charted an existential reinvention of their newspaper—in which they chose to expand beyond a particular scope of science and engineering “that had outlived its usefulness”—toward a new vision of Black and Third World student journalism under a new masthead. *The Paper* officially launched first as an October 6, 1970 insert to the *Tech News* intended to document the anti-racist and anti-colonial struggles rocking New York City, the country, and the globe. One month later, the November 19, 1970 issue printed *The*

Paper aka *Tech News* across its masthead, proclaiming *The Paper* as: “the culmination of an effort to produce a responsible Black journal at CCNY. The concept of *TECH NEWS* has outlived its usefulness. *THE PAPER* aka *Tech News*, will fulfill the purpose of projecting the realities of our world today.” *The Paper’s* transformation demonstrated how an institution (in this case, a student newspaper) can be overturned from within and reconstructed.

From the onset of Open Admissions in 1970-1971 to the end of the 1975–76 academic year, CUNY shifted from being a majority Euro student body to a predominantly Black, Latinx, and Asian student body that finally reflected the ethnic composition of the city at large. Open Admissions and the continued expansion of SEEK dramatically altered the university composition and curriculum so that previously excluded Black, Latinx, and Asian communities’ histories became recognized as worthy of rigorous study and participation. Even so, these democratizing pedagogical gains were attacked by administrators and racist faculty as soon as they had taken shape. The Board of Higher Education announced plans to implement tuition in 1976, a policy demanded by the federal government in exchange for addressing the state’s fiscal crisis. Coupled with the city’s financial crisis and the US defeat in Vietnam, the racist claim that Open Admissions only benefited poor Blacks and Puerto Ricans paved the way for the CUNY administration to impose tuition on all students.

During these same years, staffers on *The Paper* built a city-wide circulation. According to Arlette Ford, who joined the *Tech News* staff in the fall of 1969, “one of the virtues of the “new” *Tech News* was that it did not only concern itself with the reporting of City College events, but evolved into a publication reporting on national and international events and issues from a unique perspective.” Don Ford was a former officer in the Black Panther Party when he returned to City College and joined the *Tech News* staff in the fall of 1969. He would eventually become a co-editor with Al DeLeon. These student journalists were not “frivolous[;] we went to school to change our lives and to improve ourselves” (D. Ford 517). He recalls the “brilliant work” that David Friedlander did for *The Paper* about the Attica Prison riot in 1971, as well as key contributions by “Jerry Mondesire, Bob Collazo, Sekou Sundiata [formerly Bob Feaster], Charles Powell, Ray Frost, Jeff Morgan, H. Rex Linsley, John Bohn, and Maxine Alexander [as well as] Dorothy Randall, Desira Benjamin, Brunilda Pabon, and David Caldwell” (D. Ford 516). *The Paper* maintained the spirit of the Spring 1969 occupation in written form, even as the university lurched back into conservative governance, structures, and pedagogies. In this way, *The Paper* became an ongoing mobile compo-

nent of Harlem University, passed hand to hand, issuing sparks for future insurgencies despite the late 1970s CUNY retrenchment period that helped pave the way for neoliberalism (Phillips-Fein).

Amidst these student literacy innovations, Mina Shaughnessy founded *Journal of Basic Writing* in 1975, as she enshrined the imposition of “Basic Writing” philosophies and punitive testing systems. Three years later, 1978, holds a dual tragic significance: Shaughnessy passed away at the age of 54 from cancer, in the same year that CUNY students were now universally subjected to the massive high-stakes CUNY reading, writing, and math testing system—that Shaughnessy had designed and promoted—to assign them a score and a place in the university (Shor, “Our Apartheid”). Over the next thirty-five years, the CUNY Basic Skills course/testing system in its various guises did immeasurable harm to about 1.5 million CUNY students (and to their writing teachers)—until a new generation of writing teachers and WPAs organized their resistance and began to dismantle it (Molloy, *Convenient Myopia* 390).

The painful legacies of Basic Writing as a rationale for writing pedagogy formalism remain embedded today in all levels of American writing instruction and teacher training, in college writing placement tests and certification exams that funnel students into tiered course systems, in SAT and GRE tests that limit college and graduate school access, in formalist pre-packaged K-12 writing curricula and incessant student testing systems, and in mandated “Praxis” grammar tests that block access for multilingual and non-neurotypical applicants to teacher certification programs (ETS). Colleges continue to hurt new students (and their teachers) every time they label any incoming first-year students as “Basic” (Molloy, Fonville, and Salam). For the last 50 years, composition-rhetoric studies has wrestled with these concessions and testing paradigms. Meanwhile, City College’s Black and Puerto Rican students and radical SEEK educators show an alternative emancipatory road that was also taken, a legacy which can still help reconfigure our classrooms, fields of study, institutions, and communities today.

Anti-Racist Rhetorical Praxis as Literacy in Action

With this story of how *Tech News* became *The Paper*—entwined with how CCNY became Harlem University (albeit temporarily)—we signal to the institutional and interpersonal shifts that the anti-racist rhetorical praxis of working-class Black and Puerto Rican students radically conjured. *Tech News* writers worked collectively and in collaboration with others to be

effective advocates and agents for change. *Tech News* writers spoke truth to power, not just outside *the campus*, but inside it too—where opposition to racial supremacy carried real risks. From 1966 to the present, the collective writings and actions of Black and Puerto Rican CCNY students and teachers (with support from other anti-racist students and teachers) changed CCNY, as well as the entire CUNY system and city of New York, in profound and permanent ways.

Although *The Paper* continues to operate as a politically engaged “Beacon of Truth for the Unheard,” it has confronted financial difficulties like those that troubled its early-1970s forebears. Even during the late 2000s, when Coco was an undergraduate writer and editor for *The Paper*, the school’s “Tech Fund” threatened several times to decrease *The Paper*’s operating budget, while *The Campus* newspaper was institutionally buttressed by the Journalism Department. Alumni *Paper* writers seek to address this inequity with a “Paper Scholarship Fund for Social Justice” to support City College student journalist-activists.⁶

We honor those *Tech News* and *The Paper* journalists whose lives and words incited tremendous impacts upon City College, Harlem, and beyond. Louis Reyes Rivera passed away in 2012 at the age of sixty-seven. He had regularly conducted writing and performance workshops at Sista’s Place in Brooklyn, and in Fall 2011 had spoken several times to the CUNY community about the 1969 strike and *The Paper*. Obituaries commemorating Rivera’s life and work were published across CUNY newspapers and movement websites (Reed, “Remembering Louis Reyes Rivera”). CUNY videographers Martyna Starosta and Iva Radivojević produced the short film *Are You With Me?*, featuring a speech by Rivera interspersed with student and faculty mic-checks from a massive education speak-out of tens of thousands of people during an Occupy Wall Street day of action on November 17, 2011. In a beautiful tribute, *The Paper* dedicated its May 2012 issue to Rivera, including previously unpublished excerpts from the 150-page epic poem he completed just before his death, *Jazz in Jail* (Rivera).

When Sean and Coco interviewed Paul Simms in 2021, he and his wife Denise Adams Simms discussed his role at *Tech News/The Paper*, his memories of campus organizing, and how these interventions shaped their lives after City College (Simms and Simms). In July 2022, Simms passed away in Loma Linda, California. At his funeral in September, members of *The Paper* joined many in paying tribute to his legacy as a “powerhouse of Black health.” Through a brief look at this newspaper’s history, we can see that these radical students’ engagement with the written word—as part of a larger commitment

to social justice and Black liberation—provides a different praxis-oriented lens for studying CUNY students' positions in larger revolutionary struggles.

Francee Covington's role in this City College story has had a much-welcomed resurgence with the 2023 release of the film *The Five Demands*, which narrates the story of the 1969 Harlem University takeover (Schiller and Weiss). As a member of the "Committee of Ten" who led the strike, with a persistent vision for education movements, she has now inspired younger generations. In the film, she explains the necessity of defending Black Studies and (actual) affirmative action. To counter the presumption that people attend school to adhere to the status quo, she adds, "I went to college to get an education to help change the world!"

The Paper continues to publish at CCNY over fifty years later, including a series of articles that documented the April 2024 CUNY Gaza Solidarity Encampment that, for six days, transformed City College with a new Five Demands for a Free CUNY and a Free Palestine, before it was brutally demolished by the CUNY administration and NYPD (Wood; "Points of Unity & Community Agreements"). More recently, these student journalists have documented the fight for reproductive rights, the formation of the NYC Student Union, and resisting police violence under a new, more vicious, Trump regime. *The Paper* continues to act as a record of radical student composition that speaks and responds to the exigencies of this political moment, in which CUNY students and faculty who engaged in Palestine solidarity activities continue to be suspended or fired from the university (Estrine).

We recognize that these student interventions may look very different in other situations, just as activism and effective rhetoric are different in every situation. Answering Gilyard, our case study approach is inductive, not deductive—offering, we hope, some grounded critical, rhetorical alternative approaches to broad theoretical arguments that are hard to see and touch or old monolingual pedagogies that remain trapped in biased and harmful formalism. We think these are powerful illustrative examples, but we believe more examples and stories will add useful complexity and build a richer definition of anti-racist rhetorical praxis that Simms, Covington, Rivera, and others interwove between Harlem and CCNY.

We believe that anti-racist rhetorical praxis—illustrated in these ways as a writing paradigm—becomes much more than code-switching, code-meshing, lingual tourism, or a mere loosening of formal constraints. It directly challenges formalism (i.e. basic skills approaches) and objectivism (i.e. the "unbiased" nature of Eurocentric journalism). It is a means to combat racism, nativism, and embedded privileges within systems of power.

To better ascertain how to conduct radical scholarship and movement work in our present cataclysmic moment, our current debates must be rooted in a historical arc of how learning transformations (and setbacks) occurred half a century ago when white universities were challenged and altered by Black and Puerto Rican teachers and students, but then were bureaucratically constrained by wealthy Eurocentric administrators and politicians during “the fires last time.”

Learning from these student writers’ work from almost sixty years ago, we believe that praxis can ground theory in real historicized situations in both our classrooms and surrounding communities. While scholarship in teaching and learning may often place professors and writing program administrators as the focal point, *The Paper’s* writers make clear that young people of color in contexts beyond the composition classroom are incredibly innovative writing pedagogues themselves. By turning our attention to learning from them, our education systems can support and celebrate oppressed voices to use language to act in varied daring ways as we effectively move our audiences to foment social change. May these City College of New York students, and their teachers moving in kinship with them, continue to serve as a beacon for all of our efforts to apply lessons from historic struggles in our pedagogies and actions today.

Notes

1. In this essay, we capitalize “Black” and “Brown” as chosen formal designations by people of African, Caribbean, Indigenous, and Latin American descent whose self-naming was part of their emancipation, while we lower-case “white” to signal that this umbrella term homogeneously designates people of European descent (but also other ethnicities at different periods of political racialization in US history). When people capitalize “white,” this may be misconstrued as harmless, but actually cedes ground to those who intend it as a way to lionize this ahistorical racial category (i.e. White Power).
2. Much remains to be written about *Tech News/The Paper*. (See also *The Paper*, “Our Legacy,” <https://www.ccny.cuny.edu/journalism/paper.>) Gratitude to Maxine Alexander, Dee Alpert, Diane Anderson, Thomas Bell, Desira Benjamin, Sheryl Bernier, John Bohn, David Calwell, Bob Collazo, Albert DeLeon, Gwen Dixon, Ann Doris, Warren Doris, Eli Dorsey, Faviola Felix, Ted Fleming, Joudon Ford, David Friedlander, Ray Frost, Arlette Hecht, Greg Holder, Steve Holmes, Thomas Holmes, Vicky

Hunter, Jane Tillman Irving, Diane Kearny, Bob Knight, H. Rex Lindsey, Marianita Lopez, Dennis Mack, Tom McDonald, Ayad Mohamed, Jerry Mondesire, Jeff Morgan, Ray Nero, Gwen New, Chris Newton, Brunilda Pabon, Charles Powell, Dorothy Randall, Angelita Reyes, Jaime Rivera, Bill Robinson, Cynthia Valentine-Stephens, Tylie Waters, Duane Watts, Eric White, and other participants not highlighted in this article.

3. On the morning of July 16, 1964, James Powell—a fifteen-year-old Black middle-school student—was shot twice and killed by a white policeman outside Manhattan’s Robert Wagner Junior High School where Powell was attending summer classes (Jones). Three days later, residents rallied on 125th Street to protest Powell’s death and a crowd gathered in front of the 123rd Street Precinct. The New York Police Department summoned reinforcements, barricaded the block and fired shots into the air. The protests then erupted into nine days of Harlem riots, all in the shadow of CCNY’s hilltop campus (Montgomery and Clines).
4. Language and coverage choices that play into white-supremacist, colonial power structures continues to be a hallmark of the New York Times, as anti-Zionist activists have highlighted regarding *the paper’s* coverage of the genocide in Gaza. In 2024, community writing emerging out of New York City, such as the pro-Palestine grassroots newspaper the New York War Crimes, continues to be a vital site of contestation of these rhetorical norms.
5. Also during the fall of 1968, SEEK teacher Toni Cade Bambara proposed a new Center for Black and Latino Studies and described eight possible courses. In February 1969, the *Observation Post* student newspaper reprinted her proposal (Bambara, “Some” 5). Bambara even suggested course teachers, including Francee Covington (“Some” 5). Barbara Christian wrote that the idea for a Black and Puerto Rican studies program had been raised by students first in the fall of 1968 and had gradually expanded into a demand for a broader “School of Urban and Third World Studies” in the five student demands in spring 1969 (Christian). Bambara also made it clear that the student demands at City College were not unusual, arguing that “at least 90% of the several hundred rebellions” at colleges and high schools since 1964 were driven by dissatisfaction with curriculum, especially “the casual absence or deliberate overlooking of the role the African and Afro-American tradition plays in our history, our art, our culture in general” (“Some” 4). For more on these histories, see Reed.

6. *The Paper* Scholarship Fund for Social Justice, <https://www.givegab.com/campaigns/the-paper-scholarship-fund/>.

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